

Philosophical Fundamental Problems

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Philosophy does not, like other sciences, enjoy the advantage of being able to build upon immediately firm presuppositions, upon indisputable fundamental principles; for in the whole of philosophy there is not a single proposition that stands so firm that it cannot, when treated on its own, be assailed by criticism and dissolved in dialectic. For that reason philosophy cannot very well parcel out its proofs in the way that mathematics, for example, can. Although mathematical proofs must be presented in strict order if full, scientific insight is to be attained, the mathematician nevertheless does not expose himself to any essential misunderstanding if, for one purpose or another, he treats a particular problem in isolation. Those who are competent know how the presuppositions can be proved, and those whose prior knowledge does not suffice content themselves with the result of the demonstration, trusting that the foundation is firm. But upon such a trusting acquiescence the philosopher, it lies in the nature of the case, dare not reckon. In philosophy no proof can stand alone; the treatment of a separate part must borrow its light from the whole, and the comprehensive system-proof must, so to speak, be transparent in every single demonstration. But it is now well known from the history of philosophy that the systems succeed one another, so that the preceding ones always fall before those that follow. This is indeed to some extent the case in the other sciences as well, but with the—admittedly very significant—difference that certain discoveries, methods, and modes of proof either remain unassailed or at least, under a further-reaching

elaboration, yield points of support, recognizable points of departure for further progress. It is otherwise in philosophy. Here a new point of view, a new thought, a new idea cannot step out into the world as a physical or natural-historical discovery can. When a philosophical system, with its principle and its peculiar method, falls prey to critical dissolution and loses its standing, the whole is recast in such a way that, in the new casting, one can hardly recognize what the abiding element really is that the preceding system deposited. If one regards the matter exclusively from this side, one would be tempted to believe that philosophy was no true science. But the view is one-sided and therefore misleading; the misleading element lies in the fact that one takes one's models from other sciences and applies a standard that does not fit. Philosophy must necessarily have its ideal peculiarity; what essentially belongs to the invisible world of thoughts cannot possibly bear the same marks as that which can be demonstrated from piecemeal-positing conditions or exhibited in visible facts. Seen, on the contrary, from the standpoint of the development of thought and of a consciousness growing in clarity, it shows itself that philosophy, in steady historical continuation, labors at the solution of certain ever-recurring problems; that every thinker who, by placing one or more of these problems in a light advantageous to inquiry, has made a contribution to the solution, remains standing as an eminent figure in the history of philosophy; and that his contribution continues to have effect, even though his school has long since ceased to exist. For a closer understanding of this, and in order, if possible, to contribute to a somewhat clearer conception of philosophy as a science, attention is directed to the problems set forth below.

I. The Problem of Knowledge

Among the philosophers who in more recent times have treated the question of the conditions and limits of human knowledge, Imm. Kant indisputably occupies the first place—if not by the results to which his inquiries led him, then at any rate by the manner in which he has posed the problem. Earlier thinkers—whether, like Locke, they laid the emphasis on the senses, or, like Leibniz, on the understanding—simply presupposed that we know from experience what experience is, that experience is something that is understood of itself; but Kant's "*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*" shows that experience precisely is *not* something that is understood of itself, that in order

to discover which cognitions we can draw from the sources of experience, we must go back to the inviolable fundamental conditions of cognition and begin with the question of *the possibility of experience*.

It is evident that the presuppositions which the knower himself must bring with him in order to be able to make an experience cannot be borrowed from experience, even though it is only with the help of experience that they can come to consciousness. What, then, are these presuppositions? Without sensation it is impossible to apprehend the sensible, and without understanding impossible to determine what is sensed: experience is conditioned by sensation and thought; but by what is sensation conditioned, and how does it stand with the understanding? All sensation rests upon an intuiting. To sense an object in space is just as impossible without the intuition of space as it is impossible to apprehend a change in time without the intuition of time. The pure intuitions, *space and time*, are therefore a priori necessary presuppositions for all sensation and thereby for all experience. In order to procure a positive content, thought must attach itself to sensation; for the understanding is no intuiting faculty, and the old metaphysics' attempts to open up for itself a supernatural world and, by pure understanding, to make discoveries of supersensible things are fantastical. But that sensation cannot bring it about that any experience whatever is made without the assistance of the understanding is seen from this: that the one sense-impression cannot be distinguished from the other without a discriminating activity, and the one representation is not determined by the other without a judging activity. The judging understanding would not be able to exercise its activity if it did not itself contain *a priori* those root-concepts, categories, by which logical judgments must necessarily be conditioned. Which these categories are, and how many they are, can be seen from the division of judgments in formal logic. Thus the hypothetical judgment shows itself to be grounded in the categories of cause and effect, and the disjunctive in the category of reciprocity. The a priori categories of the understanding are therefore indispensable for all thought and thereby for all experience.

The pure sense-intuitions and the a priori concepts must necessarily be fundamentally different, indeed heterogeneous, since the senses are heterogeneous with the understanding; the question then arises how it is possible that forms so heterogeneous can be united in the cognizing consciousness. We are referred to the imagination, which, on the one side intellectual, on the other side sensible, by means of the intuition

of time, furnishes an a priori schema necessary for the possibility of experience. It is not enough, for example, to have assured oneself of the validity of the concept of cause as a concept alone; here a condition is required for the concept's application to the appearances in the sensible world, whereby the determinate order of time acquires decisive significance.

By pointing out the subjective fundamental conditions holding for all experience, Kant found himself able to overcome D. Hume's empirical skepticism. Hume rejected the concept of cause as a kind of habit-concept to which no experience corresponds. That things accompany and succeed one another we can experience, but that the one is cause of the other we cannot experience; what we by habit call cause is as unknown to us as what we call force. Kant grants Hume this much, in that he demonstrates the absurdity of wishing to derive the concept of cause from experience; but inasmuch as he at the same time proves that no experience whatever is possible without the concept of cause, he asserts victoriously and once and for all this concept's a-priori-empirical validity so emphatically that, according to him, experience and cause must be said to stand and fall with one another. In particular cases of experience it can often be doubtful what the cause is of an event that takes place. When A, B, and C are accompanied by D, it may perhaps be A, perhaps B, perhaps C, perhaps A and B, perhaps A and C, perhaps B and C, perhaps A, B, and C in conjunction, in which the cause of D is to be sought; for the decision of such doubtful cases one may employ induction, but induction precisely presupposes that there must be a cause.¹

Here, be it noted, there is no question of the relation between the cause and the thing itself, which falls outside our consciousness, but only of the necessity

¹"Zwar scheint es, als widerspreche dieses allen Bemerkungen, die man jederzeit über den Gang unseres Verstandesgebrauchs gemacht hat, nach welchen wir nur allererst durch die wahrgenommenen und verglichenen übereinstimmenden Folgen vieler Begebenheiten auf vorhergehende Erscheinungen, eine Regel zu entdecken, geleitet worden, der gemäss gewisse Begebenheiten auf gewisse Erscheinungen jederzeit folgen, und dadurch zuerst veranlasst worden, uns den Begriff von Ursache zu machen. Auf solchen Fuss würde dieser Begriff bloss empirisch sein und die Regel, die er verschafft: dass Alles, was geschieht, eine Ursache habe, würde eben so zufällig sein, als die Erfahrung selbst; seine Allgemeinheit und Nothwendigkeit wären alsdenn nur angedichtet und hätten keine wahre allgemeine Gültigkeit, weil sie nicht *a priori*, sondern nur auf Induction gegründet wären... Freilich ist die logische Klarheit dieser Vorstellung einer, die Reihe der Begebenheiten bestimmenden Regel, als eines Begriffs von Ursache, nur alsdenn möglich, wenn wir davon in der Erfahrung Gebrauch gemacht haben; aber eine Rücksicht auf dieselbe als Bedingung der synthetischen Einheit der Erscheinungen in der Zeit, war doch der Grund der Erfahrung selbst und ging also *a priori* vor ihr vorher." Kritik der rein. Vernunft. Leipzig 1838. S. 201.

of the concept of cause for our experience. An arbitrary play of sensations and representations is only of subjective significance and yields no experience. If a set of terms a, b, c, d, and so forth were incessantly to alter their order and mutual position without any conceivable ground whatever, we should indeed be compelled to apprehend these changes in time, but the temporal succession would give us no concept of cause and, as a matter of course, no experience either. If the image of a house, for example, changed every moment in such a way that now it turned its ridge downward, now upward, and, by the transposition of its parts, took on the shape now of a tower, now of a whale, then we should have to seek the ground of the changes in our own imagination and could in no way refer such an image to any object of experience. For the sake of experience there must be something that compels us to place the one before and the other after; it is, in other words, the necessarily determinate order of time that expresses the relation between cause and effect. The necessity is a priori, for it is a conceptual necessity; with this necessity the object is determined by experience, and experience by the object.²

From this one will understand that Kant, with inflexible rigor of consequence, must make a divorce between the object of experience (the phenomenon) and the thing in itself. There must be something that, independently of us, gives our empty forms of cognition—the sensible as well as the intellectual—a real content and determines our apprehension of the object; but that the object, as we apprehend it, cannot possibly be identical with the thing itself is a straightforward consequence of the fact that, in passing through our subjective media of cognition, it must necessarily take on a subjective tinge. Our apprehension of the thing is an alteration of the thing: we see objects through colored spectacles.

The sharp separation between the thing in itself and its appearance finds recognition in the exact sciences, particularly in the physiology of the sense-organs. Helmholtz has³ emphatically stressed that our images and representations are effects which the

²"Der Begriff, der eine Nothwendigkeit der synthetischen Einheit bei sich führt, kann nur ein reiner Verstandesbegriff sein, der nicht in der Wahrnehmung liegt, und das ist hier der Begriff des *Verhältnisses der Ursache und Wirkung*, wovon die erstere die letztere in der Zeit, als die Folge, und nicht als etwas, was bloß in der Einbildung vorhergehen (oder gar überall nicht wahrgenommen sein) könnte, bestimmt. Also ist nur dadurch, dass wir die Folge der Erscheinungen, mithin alle Veränderung dem Gesetze der Causalität unterwerfen, selbst Erfahrung d. i. empirisches Erkenntniss von denselben möglich; mithin sind sie selbst als Gegenstände der Erfahrung, nur nach eben dem Gesetze möglich." Anf. Skr. S. 196–97.

³Handbuch der physiologischen Optik. Leipzig 1867. S. 442–flgd.

intuited and represented objects produce upon our nervous system and thereby upon our consciousness. Here there is a reciprocal action between an outside and an inside, and the cause of the phenomenon is precisely this reciprocal action. To ask whether the representation I have of a table—its form, its solidity, its color, weight, and so forth—agrees with the real thing is the same as to ask whether a tone is red, yellow, or blue. Things are determined by their properties, and the properties by reciprocal action with our organs of consciousness and with other things. Cinnabar is red, be it noted, for those who can distinguish colors, but black for the red-blind. Although the latter, according to the law of reciprocal action, have the same right in their judgment as the former, we nevertheless say in general: cinnabar is red; likewise we often ascribe to a thing a property as though it belonged to the thing in itself, although this property holds only for the thing's reciprocal action with other things, as when we say: lead is soluble, and tacitly understand: in nitric acid, not in sulfuric acid. The result is that our representations of things have only practical significance. Our designations, our words and expressions, are only symbols; out of these symbols a language can be formed, expressive of our observations, exact investigations, and scientific cognitions, but which has nothing, absolutely nothing, to do with the essence of things.

If this now is the final, decisive result of the inquiry, if the problem of knowledge is herewith once and for all solved—in principle, that is—if all further-reaching research will serve only for a further confirmation of the Kantian theory: then not only must the works of Fichte, Schelling, and Hegel be regarded as misguided, but every future philosophical attempt to illuminate the essence and ground of existence must be dismissed as barren and, for science, misleading. However the matter may stand, this much is certain, that the Kantian doctrine of knowledge has an ambiguity that must be drawn forth into the light. The fundamental question is: how can that which fills our forms of cognition with *real content be so absolutely heterogeneous with these forms that the thing itself must remain entirely unknown to us?*

II. The Problem of Reality

III. The Problem of the Heterogeneous Principles